

FREE GUIDE

TYPE 4 · 4A · 4B · 4C



SCHICGIRL

NATURALS

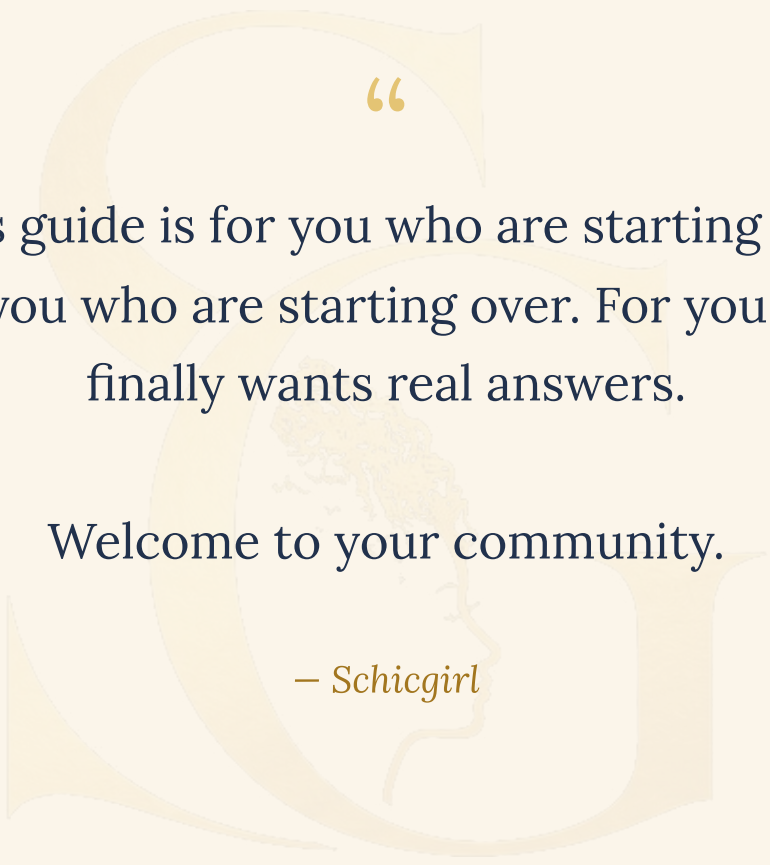
Natural hair — clarity, care & confidence

The Guide

Natural Hair Type 4

*Everything you need to start caring for your natural coily hair
— with clarity, not overwhelm.*

by Schicgirl



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This guide is for you who are starting out.
For you who are starting over. For you who
finally wants real answers.

Welcome to your community.

— *Schicgirl*

This guide is for you

If you're holding this guide, you've made an important decision: to truly care for your natural hair. Not just style it. Not just hide it. To understand it, nourish it, and love it.

Type 4 hair — 4A, 4B, 4C — is among the most beautiful and most complex hair in the world. It grows toward the sky. It forms tight coils unlike any other texture. It is a unique architecture, shaped by millennia of history.

It also asks for specific care. And if no one ever taught you how — if the products on the shelves never seem made for you, if the tutorials online don't match your texture — that is not your fault. It is simply a gap in information.

This guide is here to close that gap. In a few short chapters you'll learn the essentials: understanding your texture, building a simple routine, moisturising, protecting, and finally starting to make progress. I'm Schicgirl, and I'm with you at every step.

How to use this guide

Read one chapter at a time. Take notes. Observe your hair each week. A simple routine you keep beats a perfect one you abandon. You don't need to do everything — you need to start.

YOUR QUICK WIN — TONIGHT

Sleep in a satin bonnet or on a satin pillowcase. This one gesture, done every night, dramatically reduces breakage. You've already started.

UNDERSTAND

Understanding your Type 4 texture

Before choosing a single product, understand what you're working with. Your hair has a language — learning to read it is the foundation of everything.

| The structure of coily hair

Every strand is a spiral — a tight helix that coils around itself, with coils that may be visible to the eye or very fine, depending on your subtype. This beautiful structure creates two realities you should know.

First: the sebum produced by your scalp struggles to travel down the shaft. On straight hair it glides from root to tip; on coily hair it has to navigate dozens of bends before reaching the lengths. The result — your ends are naturally drier and more fragile.

Second — shrinkage: Type 4 hair looks much shorter than it really is. Type 4C can shrink by 50–75 %. What looks like 6 cm may be 12–15 cm when stretched.

| The subtypes: 4A, 4B, 4C

4A — visible, fairly defined coils in a tight S-shape; slightly easier to moisturise. **4B** — Z-shaped, zig-zag coils, less defined, very dense. **4C** — the tightest of the family, little natural definition, very high shrinkage, and the texture that needs the most attention to hydration.

Your type is not a hierarchy. 4C is not “below” 4A — each subtype is simply different. And many of us carry several subtypes on the same head.

| Porosity — more important than your type

Porosity is your strand's ability to absorb and hold moisture, and it matters more than your subtype. There are three levels.

Low porosity: very tightly closed cuticles — moisture struggles to get in, and out. Hair takes a long time to wet and to dry. It prefers lightweight products that penetrate easily.

Medium porosity: the ideal — cuticles open and close well, and most products work.

High porosity: open or damaged cuticles (heat, chemicals, manipulation). Moisture enters fast and leaves just as fast. It needs richer products and reliable sealants.

Schicgirl Tip — the glass test

Drop one clean, dry strand into a glass of water. Floats for a long time → low porosity. Sinks quickly → high porosity. Settles in the middle → medium porosity.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Knowing your texture and porosity is the first step to stop buying products at random — and start choosing what genuinely works for your hair.

FOUNDATIONS

The 5 fundamental needs of Type 4 hair

Understand these five needs and your routine will stop feeling complicated.

| Need 1 — Water, above all

Water is the only true hydrator — not oil, not butter, not cream. If the first ingredient on a product isn't **Water** or **Aqua**, it cannot deeply hydrate; it can only smooth or coat the surface. Your hair needs water inside the fibre to be supple.

| Need 2 — Moisture retention

Once moisture is in, it must be sealed. That's the job of oils and butters — not to hydrate, but to lock water in. A light oil (jojoba, argan) seals lightly; a butter or rich cream seals more heavily. This is the logic behind the **L.O.C.** (Liquid, Oil, Cream) and **L.C.O.** (Liquid, Cream, Oil) methods at the heart of every good Type 4 routine.

| Need 3 — Protein in balance

Your hair is keratin — a protein. Protein treatments strengthen weakened areas, but balance is everything: too much makes hair stiff and brittle; too little leaves it soft and limp. *Needs protein* if it stretches and snaps without bouncing back; *has too much* if it feels rigid and breaks at the slightest touch.

| Need 4 — A healthy scalp

Your hair grows from your scalp; if the soil is poor, the plant suffers. A healthy scalp is clean (regular cleansing), stimulated (massage), and balanced (neither too oily nor too dry). The products you put on your lengths never truly reach it — your scalp needs its own attention.

| Need 5 — Mechanical protection

Every time you touch, comb or style, friction can break the fibre — and Type 4 hair is the most prone to it, because its coils create natural tension points. The answer: less manipulation, protective styles, detangling on wet hair with slip, and protecting your hair at night.

Schicgirl Tip — order of priority

Water → moisture retention → mechanical protection → healthy scalp → protein balance. Master the first two and the rest will follow.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Your hair doesn't need 20 products. It needs 5 things done well, consistently. That is the foundation.

ROUTINE

Your first routine — simple & effective

A beginner routine that's easy to keep and effective enough to show real results. Adapt it over time.

| Wash day — once or twice a week

- 1. Pre-shampoo** (optional, recommended): coat your lengths with a light oil (coconut, olive, jojoba) and leave 15–30 min. It protects the lengths and eases detangling.
- 2. Shampoo:** use a gentle formula without SLS as the first ingredient. Massage the scalp with the pads of your fingers — never nails. Rinse well with lukewarm water.
- 3. Conditioner:** apply to the lengths (not the scalp), leave 3–5 min, then gently detangle with fingers or a wide-tooth comb, ends to roots. Rinse.
- 4. Deep conditioner** (once a week): swap your conditioner for a mask, 20–45 min, with a heated cap if you can. This is the single most important step for hydration.
- 5. Moisturise & seal (L.O.C. / L.C.O.):** on damp hair, layer leave-in, then light oil, then cream or butter. For 4C, try leave-in → cream → oil (L.C.O.) — it often penetrates tighter textures better.

| Between wash days — 2 to 3 times a week

The refresh: mist your lengths with water or a light hydrating spray, add a few drops of light oil to the ends. That's it — this keeps moisture up between washes and noticeably reduces breakage.

Scalp massage: 5 minutes with the pads of your fingers, with or without oil, to boost circulation and keep the scalp healthy.

| Every evening

The satin bonnet: before sleep, put on a satin bonnet or use a satin pillowcase. Cotton drinks up moisture and creates friction that snaps fibres. This single habit can dramatically cut breakage.

Schicgirl Tip — start small

Just three things this week — shampoo + deep conditioner + satin bonnet every night — and you've already transformed your routine. Add the rest gradually.

KEY TAKEAWAY

A simple routine kept for 90 days is worth a thousand times more than a perfect one abandoned after 10. Consistency does everything.

AVOID

The mistakes almost everyone makes

These are common — especially at the start. Knowing them is already half the work of avoiding them.

1

Using oil as a moisturiser

Oil can't enter the fibre to hydrate — it only seals moisture already there, or coats the surface. Oil on dry hair stays dry (just shiny). **Moisturise with water first.**

2

Detangling on dry hair

Type 4 hair is most fragile at its driest; detangling without slip causes massive, silent breakage. **Always detangle on wet hair with conditioner or leave-in.**

3

Washing too rarely

An uncleansed scalp builds up dead cells, residue and bacteria that slow growth and cause itching. **For Type 4, once a week or every two weeks is ideal.**

4

Changing products too often

Hair needs time to respond. Switching weekly means you can never tell what works. **Give every routine 4–8 weeks before judging.**

5

Copying someone else's routine

What works for low-porosity 4A won't always work for high-porosity 4C. *Treat the routines you see online as starting points — not formulas to copy exactly.*

6

Neglecting the ends

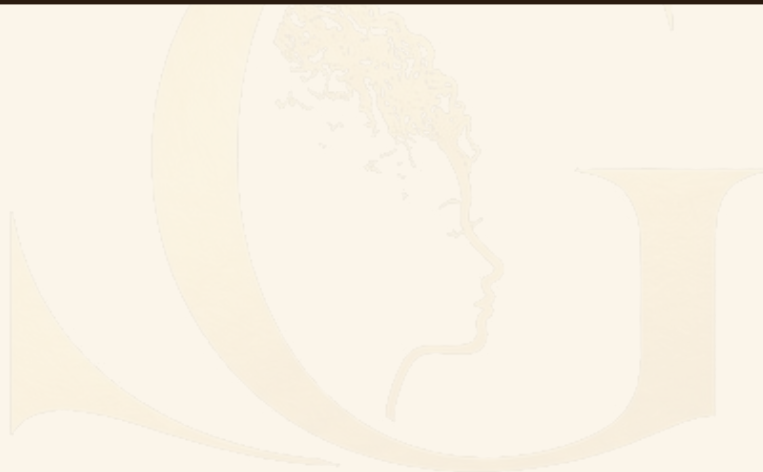
Your ends are the oldest, most fragile part of your hair. *Seal them with oil or butter after every treatment, and trim split ends roughly every 3–4 months.*

Schicgirl Tip — silent breakage

Short hair fragments in your comb (not full strands with a little bulb at the tip) are breakage, not normal shedding. They're a signal that something in your routine needs to change.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Avoiding these six mistakes puts you on a better trajectory immediately — before you add a single new product.



Ingredients to know

You don't need to become a chemist. A handful of key ingredients lets you read labels and choose better.

Look for

Water / Aqua at the top of any moisturiser. **Aloe vera** (soothing, balances pH). **Glycerin** (a humectant that draws moisture in — great for Type 4). **Panthenol** (B5, strengthens and adds elasticity). **Light oils** (jojoba, argan, grapeseed — seal without weighing down; ideal for 4A/4B). **Rich oils** (castor, avocado — seal more heavily; ideal for high-porosity 4C).

Watch for, near the top of the list

SLS (Sodium Lauryl Sulfate): too harsh — prefer gentler Sodium Laureth Sulfate or sulphate-free. **Petrolatum / Paraffinum Liquidum**: can clog follicles over time. **Alcohol Denat.**: very drying. Note: fatty alcohols (Cetyl, Cetearyl) are actually moisturising — don't confuse the two.

The rule of the first five

The first five ingredients make up most of a product. If water sits at position 6 or 7, the product is mostly something else. If you only read one thing on a label, read the first five.

Schicgirl Tip

Install INCIDecoder or CosDNA on your phone — paste any ingredient list and instantly see what each component does.

SCALP

Caring for your scalp

The scalp is the soil your hair grows from. Neglect the soil and you starve the growth — yet it's the step most beginners skip.

| Why the scalp comes first

Follicles need a healthy environment to produce strong hair. A scalp clogged with residue, irritated by harsh ingredients, or smothered by heavy oils can't work properly — leading to slowed growth, more shedding, flakes or itching.

| Scalp massage — the number-one gesture

Massage boosts circulation, which feeds the follicles; studies show measurable effects on hair thickness over time. Use the pads of your fingers (never nails) in small circles across the whole scalp. **4–5 minutes, 3–5 times a week** — with or without oil.

| Choosing the right shampoo

Your shampoo cleanses the scalp above all. Look for a gentle formula made for natural or textured hair, and once a month use a clarifying shampoo to remove build-up. A truly clean scalp feels remarkably different — lighter, more comfortable, more ready to grow.

Signs your scalp needs attention

Persistent itching; heavy flaking (white and dry = lack of moisture; yellow and oily = possible seborrheic dermatitis); redness or tender patches; a tight or burning feeling; widespread shedding across the whole scalp. If several appear together, start by clarifying and cutting back the heavy products you apply directly to the scalp.

Schicgirl Tip

Keep thick butters and heavy oils off your scalp — those are for your lengths. For the scalp, use light oils (jojoba, diluted peppermint) or a scalp-specific serum.

Schicgirl Reminder

Growth is invisible work. You won't see results in a week — but a cared-for scalp today is the length you'll celebrate in six months.

KEY TAKEAWAY

A healthy scalp produces healthy hair. Five minutes of massage a day and the right shampoo every week or two — that's the minimum investment that changes everything.

PROTECT

Protective styles — retention & freedom

Protective styles aren't for hiding your hair. They're an active strategy to retain length and let your hair rest.

| The best styles for Type 4

Knotless braids — less root tension than box braids (4–6 weeks max). **Two-strand twists** — easy to redo (1–2 weeks). **A low, loose bun** — simple and daily; skip elastics with metal clasps. **Wigs & extensions** — protective when installed without excess tension on edges and scalp.

Schicgirl Rules — the four golden rules

1) Never install on dirty hair or an irritated scalp — start clean and moisturised. 2) Never go beyond 6–8 weeks without taking the style down and inspecting. 3) Keep moisturising the scalp underneath (light spray 2–3×/week, gentle massage). 4) If it hurts during install, it's too tight — pain is a warning, not beauty.

Schicgirl Tip — take-down

Before removing a protective style, saturate your hair with a nourishing oil or conditioner. It softens knots and can cut take-down breakage by 60–80 %.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Protective styles are one of the most effective length-retention strategies — when they're well managed and the scalp is cared for underneath.

WITHIN

Diet, hydration & lifestyle

Your hair is alive — it grows from a body. What you put into that body shows up on your head.

Nutrients for strong hair

Protein (keratin is protein — one source per meal: lean meat, fish, eggs, legumes, tofu). **Iron** (a common deficiency causing diffuse shedding; lentils, spinach, lean red meat — vitamin C boosts absorption). **Zinc** (regulates sebum; pumpkin seeds, cashews). **Omega-3** (anti-inflammatory; salmon, sardines, flax, walnuts). **Vitamin D** (a deficit is linked to hair loss — have levels checked if unsure).

Water, stress & sleep

A dehydrated body makes dehydrated hair — aim for 1.5–2 L of water a day. Cortisol, the stress hormone, can push follicles into early rest (shedding weeks later), and under 6 hours of sleep slows growth. Your body — and your hair — repair while you rest.

Schicgirl Tip — the simple rule

Drink your water, eat your protein, sleep in your satin bonnet, and tackle one source of stress each week. Not perfect — just enough to start.

KEY TAKEAWAY

No cream can make up for a poorly nourished body. The best hair care begins on your plate and in your bed.

BEGIN

Your starter checklist

You have the foundations. Here's your list of concrete actions to begin this very week.

THIS WEEK — your 5 starting actions

- ☐ Identify your porosity (glass-of-water test)
- ☐ Do a full wash day with a deep conditioner (20 min minimum)
- ☐ Apply the L.O.C. or L.C.O. method after washing
- ☐ Sleep with a satin bonnet every night
- ☐ Photograph your stretched hair — your starting point

EVERY WEEK — your basic habits

- ☐ 1–2 wash days, depending on your needs
- ☐ Moisture refresh, 2–3 times
- ☐ Scalp massage, 3 times (5 min each)
- ☐ Satin bonnet every night

EVERY MONTH — to keep progressing

- ☐ Stretched-length photo to track progress
- ☐ Clarifying shampoo to remove build-up
- ☐ Routine check: what's working? what isn't? Trim if ends need it

ONE LAST WORD FROM SCHICGIRL  SCHICGIRL

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You've just read the essentials. Now the most important thing isn't what you know — it's what you do.

One gesture. This week. Just one.

Your hair won't transform overnight. But with every gesture made on purpose, you're building something real: a relationship, an understanding, a progression.

And you're not alone in any of it.

— *With so much love, Schicgirl*



YOUR NATURAL NEXT STEP

Continue your hair journey

This free guide gave you the foundations. If one thing changes everything for Type 4 hair, it's hydration — and that's exactly where I'd go next with you.

Hydrated — the Type 4 hydration handbook

\$13 · 8 000 XOF

The science of moisture for natural Type 4 hair

What it solves

The number-one Type 4 struggle: hair that drinks up water then feels dry again by afternoon. *Hydrated* is about moisture that finally lasts.

Who it's for

Anyone whose hair stays thirsty, dull or brittle — especially high-porosity and 4C textures — and anyone ready to move from “starting” to “retaining length.”

What you'll learn

- L.O.C. / L.C.O. mastery, matched to your porosity
- Deep conditioning that actually penetrates the fibre
- Simple refresh routines that hold moisture between washes
- DIY recipes you can make at home

Discover Hydrated

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